James and the Giant Peach

By Roald Dahl

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Suggested Roles:

ACTOR 1: *Narrator 1, Aunt Spiker, Old Man, Grasshopper, Centipede, Earthworm, Chief of Police,*

ACTOR 2: *Narrator 2, Aunt Sponge, James, Spider, Ladybird, Head of Fire Department*

NOTE: The comedy in this selection comes from the creativity of the actors to create both speaking and non-speaking characters through body stances and sounds (singularly and together). Think of ways to "show" Mother, Father, the rhino, the tree, the hole in the peach. the seagulls, citizens of NYC and the Empire State Building.

NARRATOR 1: **(Chpt 1)** Until he was four years old, James Henry Trotter *(James play happily)* had a happy life. *(Speaking over James' playing)* He lived peacefully with his mother and father in a beautiful house beside the sea. It was the perfect life . . . . *(James resumes playing)* Then one day a terrible thing happened. *(James freezes)* James's mother and father went to the zoo.

NARRATOR 2: Both of them suddenly got eaten up by an enormous angry rhinoceros which had escaped.

NARRATOR 1: Poor James was sent away to live with his Aunt Sponge and Aunt Spiker.

AUNT SPONGE and AUNT SPIKER: *(together)* You filthy nuisance!

NARRATOR 2: I am sorry to say they were both really horrible people.

AUNT SPONGE: You disgusting little beast!

AUNT SPIKER: You miserable creature! *(James begins to cry)* **(Chpt 2)** What's the matter with you?

AUNT SPONGE: Beat him!

AUNT SPIKER: I certainly will! *(She glares at James who is very frightened)*

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INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 2: *James Henry Trotter, a lonely orphan living with two unkind and malicious guardians, longs for friends.*
ACTOR 1: *When a magical peach grows in his backyard, he unexpectedly finds companionship with a rag-tag bunch of characters.*
ACTOR 2: *Their journey together is exceptional as they overcome obstacles beyond imagination.*
ACTOR 1: *And James is transformed by the power of friendship, trust and the shared challenges they face.*
ACTOR 2: *He comes to realize the truth in this quote by Edna Buchanan: "Friends are the family we choose for ourselves."*
TOGETHER: *James and the Giant Peach by Roald Dahl.*

NARRATOR 2: **(Chpt 3)** [One day a] rather peculiar thing happened to [James].

OLD MAN: *(emerging from behind James)* Come, little boy! *(beckoning)* Come and I will show you something ***wonderful***! *(he puts his hand into the pocket of his jacket and takes out a small bag and waves it in front of James's face; James is enthralled)* Take a look! Listen to them move! *(James listens [insert sound effect]) (softly)* There's more power and magic in there than in all the rest of the world put together!

JAMES: But – but – what ***are*** they?

OLD MAN: Crocodile tongues! Boiled for twenty days with the eyeballs of a lizard! *(he pushes the bag into James's hands)* Here! Take it! It's yours! **(Chpt 4)** And don't let those green things escape. Because if they do . . . Whoever they meet first, be it bug, insect, or tree, will get the full power of their magic! Marvelous things will start happening to you – and you will never be miserable again. Off you go! Hurry! *(James exits at a run)*

NARRATOR 1: **(Chpt 5)** James was running back towards the house as fast as he could. Then suddenly, just as he was passing the old peach tree, his foot slipped and he fell flat on his face. *(James trips and loses all the green things in the bag, he is frantically searching for them when Aunt Spiker enters)*

AUNT SPIKER: Get up at once, you lazy little beast! Get over there and finish chopping those logs!

******** Scene break*******

AUNT SPIKER: **(Chpt 6)** *(staring in awe at the top of the peach tree)* Sponge! Sponge! Come here and look at this! It's a peach!

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JAMES: *(looking up at the tree)* Something peculiar is about to happen . . . .

AUNT SPONGE: *(preoccupied doing something else)* A what? That miserable tree never has any peaches on it. *(She sees the enormous peach)* There really is a peach up there!

AUNT SPIKER: A nice big one too!

AUNT SPONGE: Why don't we eat it! *(licking her lips)*

AUNT SPIKER: *(in terror)* It's getting bigger! Great heavens alive!

NARRATOR 2: **(Chpt 7)** Bigger and bigger grew the peach. It grew as tall and wide as a small house. The bottom part of it gently touched the ground and there it rested.

JAMES: Oh, isn't it beautiful. It's the most beautiful thing I've ever seen.

AUNT SPIKER: Shut up, you little twerp! It's none of your business. *(walking around the peach)* There's a pile of money to be made out of this if we handle it right! **(Chpt 8)** *(strutting around)* Roll up! Only one shilling to see the giant peach!

****** Scene break*****

NARRATOR 1: Later, when the people had all gone home . . .

JAMES: *(opening the door)* Could I please have something to eat?

AUNT SPIKER: *(slamming the door shut)* No! We are counting our money! *(She cackles and James exits, dejected)*

NARRATOR 1: **(Chpt 9)** James, as though drawn by some powerful magnet, started walking towards the giant peach. *(James enacts the narrator's words, he rubs his cheek against the peach)*

JAMES: *(in awe)* Something stranger than ever this time is about to happen to me again!

NARRATOR 1: Suddenly he happened to notice there was a hole in the side of the peach. *(James crawls inside)*

JAMES: **(Chpt 10)** This isn't a hole . . . It's a tunnel! *(he continues to follow the tunnel and then suddenly – bang – the top of his head bumps into something hard)* Good Heavens! I've come to the stone in the middle! *(He pries open a door in the peach stone and steps through and reacts with large, frightened eyes)*

SPIDER: **(Chpt 11)** I'm hungry!

GRASSHOPPER: I'm famished!

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CENTIPEDE: *(wriggling)* Everyone's famished! We need food!

GRASSHOPPER: *(to James, who does look quite ill, shivering with fright)* You look positively ill!

CENTIPEDE: Cheer up, my boy! **(Chpt 12)** *(bragging and wagging his feet to introduce himself)* Centipede. I have a lot of legs. One hundred, to be exact.

EARTHWORM: There he goes again! Telling lies about his legs! He's only got forth two! There's nothing marvelous about having a lot of legs. The ***really*** marvelous thing is to have no legs at all and to be ablet to walk just the same.

CENTIPEDE: You call that walking! You're a ***slitherer***. You just ***slither*** along!

EARTHWORM: *(primly)* I glide.

CENTIPEDE: You are a slimy beast.

EARTHWORM: I am ***not*** a slimy beast!

CENTIPEDE: *(growing tired of harassing Earthworm)* James? Have you ever in your life seen such a marvelous colossal Centipede as me?

JAMES: I certainly haven't. How on earth did you get to be like that?

CENTIPEDE: Very peculiar, indeed. I was under the old peach tree and suddenly a funny little green thing came wriggling past my nose.

EARTHWORM: *(proudly)* I actually swallowed one!

JAMES: Oh! I know what that was!

SPIDER: There were little green things everywhere!

GRASSHOPPER: It's too late to tell stories now. It's time to go to sleep! **(Chpt 14)** *(suddenly the peach shook as if in an earthquake)*

JAMES: What's happening? What's going on?

******** Scene break*******

(Centipede chews through the peach stem with a purpose)

LADYBIRD (off stage): At this moment, Centipede is nibbling away at the stem. We are about to depart forever from the top of this ghastly hill and those two repulsive aunts of yours.

CENTIPEDE: I've done it! The journey begins!

NARRATOR 2: Slowly . . .

NARRATOR 1: Insidiously . . .

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NARRATOR 2: Oh, most gently. . . The great peach started to lean forward and steal into motion.

GRASSHOPPER and JAMES: *(crashing into furniture, walls and each other)*

******** Scene break*******

AUNT SPONGE: **(Chpt 15)** I wonder what became of that horrid little boy last night.

AUNT SPIKER: He probably fell down in the dark and broke his leg.

AUNT SPONGE: Or his neck! *(She cackles)*

AUNT SPIKER: *(sound effect inserted here)* Good gracious me! What's that awful noise? *(Both turn around and react in terror. They try to scramble out of the path of the peach, but . . . . screams)*

NARRATOR 1: And then there was silence. Aunt Sponge and Aunt Spiker lay lifeless. The peach?

NARRATOR 2: **(Chpt 16)** A round object will keep rolling as long as it is on a downhill slope.

NARRATOR 1: In this case the land sloped downhill all the way to . . . .

******** Scene break*******

(Atop the peach)

JAMES: **(Chpt 18)** *(bobbing gently)* We're in the middle of the sea!

GRASSHOPPER: *(also bobbing but trying to keep the fear out of his voice)* I am afraid we find ourselves in a rather awkward situation.

EARTHWORM: Awkward! We are finished!

JAMES: *(reassuringly)* We are floating beautifully. Sooner or later a ship is bound to come along.

EARTHWORM: If we are not going to be drowned, then we are going to starve to death instead!

CENTIPEDE: Earthworm is right!

JAMES: We have enough food here for weeks!

SPIDER: Where?

JAMES: The peach of course! *(he breaks off a piece and takes a bite)* Our whole ship is made of food!

GRASSHOPPER: *(taking a bite too)* Jumping Jehoshophat!

SPIDER: *(lassoing a piece of peach with her web)* Isn't it glorious! The finest dinner in the world!

CENTIPEDE: **(Chpt 19)** *(looks over the side of the peach and pointing with many of his legs)* Look! Look at that funny black thing gliding through the water!

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EARTHWORM: Sharks!!!!

GRASSHOPPER: *(looking on the bright side)* Perhaps they have come to say hello? *(James looks over the side nervously)*

SPIDER: We are finished now! They will eat the peach and there'll be nothing left to stand on. *(Grasshopper shakes his head and moans – James tries to comfort him)*

EARTHWORM: I don't want to be eaten!

CENTIPEDE: *(panicked)* Come on, James. There ***must*** be ***something*** we can do.

JAMES: **(Chpt 20)** I . . . I . . . I . . .

SPIDER: **(Chpt 19)** Think, James, think!

JAMES: **(Chpt 20)** There is something We'd need string to make this work!

SPIDER: I can spin *(she demonstrates)* As much as you want. But why?

JAMES: *(firmly)* I'm going to lift this peach clear out of the water!

GRASSHOPPER: The boy's crazy.

LADYBIRD: How are you going to do it?

JAMES: Seagulls! I'm going to take a long silk string and loop one end round a seagull's neck *(Spider begins spinning and hands the product to James)* and tie the other end to the stem of the peach. *(James pantomimes and seagull squawks) (with authority)* **(Chpt 21)** Action stations! There's not a moment to lose! *(James smiles as the peach begins to rise)*

NARRATOR 1: **(Chpt 22)** Suddenly. Slowly . . . Majestically

NARRATOR 2: The giant peach rose out of the water like some fabulous golden balloon.

EARTHWORM: **(Chpt 23)** Good-bye, sharks!

CENTIPEDE: Oh, boy, this is the way to travel!

****** Scene break*****

NARRATOR: **(Chpt 31)** Faster and faster flew the seagulls [until] **(Chpt 33)** far below them, in the City of New York, pandemonium was breaking out. *(cries from townspeople as they spy the giant peach)* A ball as big as a house had been sighted in the sky. It was an enormous bomb sent to blow the city to smithereens! Air-raid sirens began wailing *(insert sound effect here)* **(Chpt 36)** James could see the skyscrapers rushing up to meet them. The very tallest of them all had a top that tapered off into a long sharp point.

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JAMES: Good-bye, Centipede. Good-bye everybody! *(the peach lands on the top of spike of the Empire State Building insert sound effect here)*

NARRATOR 2: Suddenly – there was the giant peach, caught on upon the very pinnacle of the Empire State Building

CHIEF OF POLICE: **(Chpt 37)** It's a Snozzwanger!

HEAD OF THE FIRE DEPT: It's a Whangdoodle!

JAMES: *(realizing he's alive, he peesr over the side of the peach and waves)* Hello, everybody! Hello! Don't be frightened. We are so glad to be here!

CHIEF OF POLICE: What about the others? Are any of them dangerous?

JAMES: Of course not! [This is] Spider with a mile of thread inside her. Grasshopper is a boon in millions of ways. This is Centipede. He is so sweet and gentle. And Earthworm? Absolutely grand! *(townspeople cheer)*

NARRATOR 1: **(Chpt 39)** And thus the journey ended. But the travelers lived on. Centipede became Vice President of a high-class boot manufacturer.

NARRATOR 2: Earthworm made commercials on television for women's face creams.

NARARTOR 1: Miss Spider set up a factory and made ropes for tightrope walkers.

NARRATOR 2: Old-Green-Grasshopper became a member of the New York Symphony Orchestra

NARRATOR 1: And the enormous peach stone was set up in a place of honor in Central Park. It became a famous house. And inside the famous house lived a famous person. *(James opens the door and steps outside)* James Henry Trotter . . . once the saddest and loneliest boy that you could find . . . now had all the friends in the world.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Roald Dahl
ISBN: 978-0140374247
Publisher: Puffin
Date (Month/Year): April 2000

AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
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